

“I thought it
my duty to
ride up to the
hut ... and do
**my woman’s
work.**”

MARY SEACOLE, EMBARKING ON THE SHIP
TO BALACLAVA, 1854

NURSING ON THE FRONT

Mary Seacole, a Jamaican-born nurse, played a pioneering role in caring for British soldiers in the Crimean War (1853-1856). When Seacole offered her services as a nurse, she was rejected by various British government offices due to racial discrimination. In contrast to Seacole’s experiences, white women were warmly welcomed. Undaunted, Seacole traveled to the Crimean Peninsula using her own resources. She arrived in Balacava in 1854 where, at her own expense, she tended to the wounded and established a “British Hotel,” which provided food, drinks, and supplies for soldiers. Although Seacole’s contribution faded from memory after her death, in the late 20th century she received wide recognition and was awarded the Jamaican Order of Merit in 1991.

